	7.17. MANAGEMENT OF NON-CONFORMING WORK	
	Document no: ASMF7.17	
Compiled by:	Sifiso Nyambi - Laboratory Manager	
Approved by:	Nonhlanhla Msibi - Operations Manager	

Applies to: All stages of Proficiency Testing and reference material (RM or CRM) production including sampling, characterization, homogeneity, stability, certification, labelling, and distribution.

1. Purpose

To define the procedure for identifying, documenting, evaluating, correcting, and preventing recurrence of any non-conforming work (NCW) that could affect the quality, integrity, or validity of certified reference materials (CRMs) or candidate RMs.

2. Scope

This applies to:

- RM/CRM batches failing stability or homogeneity requirements
- Incorrect property value assignments or uncertainty estimations
- Equipment malfunction affecting measurement validity
- Labelling, packaging, or CoA errors
- Any deviation from production or testing procedures
- Incorrect traceability or documentation

3. Responsibilities

Role	Responsibility
Lab Manager	Authorize containment and initiate investigation
Lab Supervisor	Lead root cause analysis and maintain NCW register
Lab analyst/ operator	Report and document non-conforming work immediately

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Effective date	Rev status	Next review date
07/2025	00	07/2028

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Role	Responsibility
Operations Manager	Approve final corrective actions and ensure traceability of decisions

4. Identification of non-conformity

Sources may include:

- Observation during routine work or supervision
- Internal audits
- Stability/homogeneity test failures
- Customer complaints
- Out-of-spec test results
- Incorrect CoA's or labelling errors

5. Initial Actions

- Immediately halt use of affected RM/CRM or process step.
- Label the product or isolate the equipment with "NON-CONFORMING" tags.
- Notify the Laboratory/Operations Manager.
- Begin an NCW Report Form (paper).

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6. Documentation

Each NCW must be documented using a controlled form/log that includes:

- Unique NCW ID
- Date/time of detection
- Process stage affected
- Description of non-conformance
- Responsible person(s)
- Immediate action taken (containment)
- Signature of person reporting

7. Evaluation and Risk Assessment

Assess whether the non-conformance:

- Affects previously released RMs/CRMs
- Requires rework, retesting, or full recall
- Risks invalidating assigned property values or traceability
- Has occurred before (recurring issue)

Use a **risk matrix** to evaluate severity and urgency.

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8. Corrective Actions

Once root cause is confirmed:

- Define the correction and corrective action
- Assign responsible personnel and target dates
- Validate effectiveness after implementation
- Document updates to SOPs, training, or process controls if needed

9. Follow-Up and Closure

- Verify the corrective action eliminated or mitigated the issue
- Retest or recharacterise RM/CRM batch if necessary
- Document closure with review sign-off from operations/lab manager
- Update NCW register and archive all records securely

10. Record Retention

- NCW records must be stored for **minimum of 10 years**, linked to batch records.
- Include them in management review for trend analysis.

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